Christopher R McGuire

Strategic Product Leader & SVP of Engineering/UX/UI Design

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Trailblazing technology leader recognized for pioneering **front-end transformations**, and **driving innovation**, directing **user-centric design**, and guiding **AI-integrated solutions**. Proven record delivering *measurable* cost savings, productivity boosts, and innovative frameworks that align technology roadmaps to firm OKRs. Passionate about merging technical rigor with intuitive design to accelerate product cycles, increase user satisfaction, and modernize legacy systems. Adept in **building and leading global teams** to innovate, architect, and execute multiple **real-time and data intensive applications** and fortifying software with scalable, secure infrastructures.

EXPERIENCE

Senior VP, Head of App Design and Development – MESIROW – Chicago, IL *May 2024 - Present*

- **Cut vendor spend by 75%**, replacing a $330k/yr web provider with Webflow, empowering Marketing to own 90% of updates – eliminating dev bottlenecks.
- **Erased 2+ years of technical debt** by retiring legacy Cold Fusion code, *reducing security risk* exposure and ongoing support costs.
- **Reduced maintenance workflow 40%** by migrating legacy HR Java apps to Microsoft Power Apps, enabling HR to self-manage workflows – freeing dev capacity for revenue-generating projects.
- **Accelerated product feature delivery by 30%** through **training teams on AI, guiding prompt engineering best practices, and pioneering AI (GPT/Claude/LLM) workflows** for application documentation, requirements generation, and code design and development, enabling faster innovation and iteration across product initiatives.
- **Spearheaded a comprehensive full-stack workflow and platform overhaul**, strategically aligning technology delivery with firmwide OKRs to ensure scalable and coherent product development.
- Developed **Mesirow's first internal CustomGPT**, integrating firm-specific architecture, process documentation, and internal knowledge to streamline new hire onboarding and empower employee self-service for institutional knowledge access

VP of Engineering and UX/UI Design – AKUNA CAPITAL – Chicago, IL *Jun 2021 – Jan 2023*

- **Built and scaled a high-performing product and engineering team of 15**, establishing robust onboarding and career paths that enhanced talent retention and morale, fostering a joyful and high-performance environment.
- **Integrated real-time analytics** across 20+ apps with Grafana, boosting ops efficiency and overall QA test accuracy.
- Directed **agile development for 20+ user-facing front-end applications**, significantly cutting release times and improving real-time data flow to enhance the coherent user experience across our multi-product suite.

Director of Product, Design and Engineering – SPIDERROCK – Chicago, IL *Nov 2019 – Jun 2021*

- Led the comprehensive **overhaul of UI/UX strategy across 10+ multi-product applications**, creating and implementing a robust **design system library** to ensure platform coherence, elevate user experience, and accelerate development velocity.
- Developed a fintech roadmap for options block trading dashboard — wireframes and prototypes automated trader workflows.

Engineering Director of UX/UI Design & Development – CITADEL – Chicago, IL *Jan 2005 – Jan 2019*

- **Pioneered the establishment of the firm's first global UX/UI team**, expanding its scale from 5 to 20+ professionals across multiple locations, laying the foundational framework for consistent, high-craft product experiences
- Rolled out a scalable micro-UI & microservices architecture, **boosting performance of 25+ Equities apps**.

- Architected and implemented a **reusable React component library**, serving as a cornerstone of the firm's internal design system, which **reduced UI development time by 50%** and ensured coherent, high-craft user experiences across various product offerings.
- Directed **native mobile app development (iOS/Android) for 50+ research desks**, optimizing critical analyst and trader workflows to enable seamless productivity and real-time collaboration from anywhere.
- Drove a **40% improvement in user satisfaction** through a strategic **Global Equities UX/UI redesign**, directly impacting key user adoption and engagement metrics across the platform.
- Built reusable WPF/web control library — **reduced dev time by 15%, improved UI consistency**, and grew revenue.

EDUCATION

Purdue University *Aug 1992 - Dec 1996*
Bachelor of Science in Computer and Electrical Engineering West Lafayette, IN

AI and Emerging Technologies

- **Leveraged AI/LLM technologies** (GPT, Claude, Gemini, Grok, LLaMA) and **code generation tools to augment dev workflows**, accelerate **prototyping** of internal applications, and inform strategic product decisions, aligning with modern product iteration strategies.
- Integrated LLMs (GPT models – documentation / analysis, Claude – coding / analysis / documentation, Gemini - coding, Grok – brainstorming sessions, LLaMA – experimentation with local model capabilities) to augment dev workflows, legal drafting, documentation, and architecture review both at Mesirow and in personal projects.
- Used Lovable, *Cline*, *Roo*, and *Bolt, Gemini CLI, Firebase Studio* code generation tools to prototype and deploy internal apps, including:
  - **Application Inventory and Skills Management System**
  - **Visual Sequence Diagram Generator**
  - **System Dependency Matrix Tool**
- Applied **prompt engineering** for high-accuracy code generation, architecture visualization, and compliance document production.
- Created internal AI workshop materials for team upskilling and safe deployment of LLM-based enhancements into SDLC.

SELECTED INDEPENDENT PROJECTS

- **Thrive Financial** AI-assisted legal application and forensic accountant tool (Gemini 2.5 Flash, React, Node.js, Firebase, Tailwind, Figma)
- **Modus AI** mobile AI interior and exterior designer with dimension and furniture locks (React Native, Generative AI, Expo, Figma)
- **Modernized** personal website with Generative AI and launched several AI-enhanced SaaS tools:
  - **Thrive Logger** – iOS app to quickly categorize and log incidents, maintaining an audit trail
  - **IconForge.net –** custom icon library builder with export options (SVG/PNG)
  - **FiscalCompass.net –** no-auth financial calculator suite and blog powered by LLM-generated and QA-verified content

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Languages**: JavaScript, C#, HTML, CSS, Python, Java, SQL
- **Frameworks**: React, Node.JS, Redux, React Native, Express, Svelte, WPF, WinForms, Electron, iOS, Android, PWA
- **AI/LLM Tools**: Prompt Engineering, ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Grok, Lovable, Roo Code, Cline, Bolt.new, Gemini/Claude CLI
- **AI Use Cases**: Code generation, bug diagnosis, design implementation, legal support, data analysis, documentation
- **Tools**: Figma, Mongo, Adobe CS, Tableau, Grafana, Datadog, MS Azure, Git, Balsamiq, Chat GPT, DALL-E
- **Process**: SDLC, Quality Assurance, Cross-Team Leadership, UX, UI, Strategic Planning, Data Analysis/Visualization, Product